swimmers (Boudouresque et al ., 1990). Verlaque (1991) noted its presence around the Lavezzi Islands.

Critical habitat

1.13 This area offers great potential for the conservation of a large number of nationally important habitats and species. Certain species (the European shag, the giant limpet Patella ferruginea) are present in numbers which provide the nucleus of genetically stable populations that may be considered source populations capable of providing the starting point for colonization (natural or artificial) of potential habitats, to differing degrees,

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SOURCE: MEPC.204(62).pdf
populations that may be considered source populations capable of providing the starting point for colonization (natural or artificial) of potential habitats, to differing degrees,
depending on the manner in which the larvae and individual representatives of those species are distributed. This area of the Strait of Bonifacio is thus of vital importance for declining populations or small sub-populations of species. For example, conservation of the national gene pool of threatened meta-populations of species such as the giant limpet could allow it to be reintroduced into areas of the Mediterranean where it is now extinct.

1.14 The care of this area is also very important to marine avifauna. This is a major site for the European shag (Phalacrocorax aristotelis aristotelis) and for sizeable numbers of Cory's shearwater (Calonectris diomedea). The Strait of Bonifacio is also a main point for the passage, roosting and feeding of the Yelkouan shearwater. The whole area is a feeding ground for these species.

1.15 The European shag population does not exceed 10,000 pairs across the whole of its

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the passage, roosting and feeding of the Yelkouan shearwater. The whole area is a feeding ground for these species.

1.15 The European shag population does not exceed 10,000 pairs across the whole of its small area of distribution in the Mediterranean. The Strait of Bonifacio has high priority in the conservation of this species. In 2001, the nesting population of the Strait of Bonifacio represented more than 50 per cent of the French population and 7 per cent of the world population. The main problems for this species are disturbance to nesting sites, accidental capture during small-scale fishing and the di sappearance of habitats owing to the expansion of tourism.

1.16 The nesting population of Cory's shearwater accounts for 40 per cent of the national nesting total. With 345 pairs, the Lavezzu island colony is the most numerous in France.

This species is on the decline owing to the introduction of allocthonous species (dogs, cats

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nesting total. With 345 pairs, the Lavezzu island colony is the most numerous in France. This species is on the decline owing to the introduction of allocthonous species (dogs, cats and rats), the removal of eggs from certain colonies and the development of tourism, which disturbs colonies and destroys habitat.

1.17 With around 200 nesting pairs within the perimeter of the area, the population of the highly unobtrusive storm petrel (Hydrobates pelagicus) represents around one third of the French Mediterranean population and between 15 and 18 per cent of the French population including Atlantic birds. Europe's smallest marine bird (15 cm) is in steep decline in the Mediterranean, mainly owing to the introduction of predators such as the black rat (Rattus rattus). The colonies are now highly localized and concentrated, making them very vulnerable.

Dependency

1.18 The main ecosystems of the Strait of Bonifacio area, whether deep-sea or coastal, are closely interconnected: pelagic open-water systems, gulfs, intertidal zone, supralittoral environments, islets and lagoons.

1.19 Being an open system, the marine environment does not experience fragmentation

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are closely interconnected: pelagic open-water systems, gulfs, intertidal zone, supralittoral environments, islets and lagoons.

1.19 Being an open system, the marine environment does not experience fragmentation of habitats to the same degree as the land environment. In the Strait of Bonifacio the long-protected areas of the Lavezzi, the fish confinement areas and the decreed biotopes of the Monk and Bruzzi islands shelter balanced populations which embrace all age-groups and assure the reproduction of larvae (fish, crustaceans, ...) and their diffusion to more recently established nature reserves. Plankton production and the gathering of animal larvae condition the introduction of both marine and littoral trophic chains. By virtue of its geographical position and the existence of violent currents which facilitate larva distribution, the Strait of Bonifacio could play a not inc onsiderable role in coastal fishing management in the north-western Mediterranean.

1.20 While the plankton-eating organisms are an indispensable resource for large pelagic species, seriolae and tuna, not to mention cetaceans (particularly bottlenose dolphins), they

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the north-western Mediterranean.

1.20 While the plankton-eating organisms are an indispensable resource for large pelagic species, seriolae and tuna, not to mention cetaceans (particularly bottlenose dolphins), they are also attractive to the marine birds present (European shag, Cory's shearwater, seagulls).

Representativeness

1.21 Beds of Posidonia oceanica, high-priority protected habitats, are widely represented. A Posidonia bed is a very valuable ecosystem from the biodiversity point of view, and is also very important to fishing, coastal protection and the enrichment of certain other coastal ecosystems. It is an excellent indicator of the overall quality of the natural environment. In many parts of the Mediterranean, it has been seriously affected by human activities, and some beds are in serious decline. Beds of Posidonia oceanica are characteristic of the infralittoral stage in the Mediterranean. Those in the Strait of Bonifacio area cover more than 5,000 ha and are in excellent condition. They play a leading role in the area's productivity and provide sites for breeding, spawning and raising young.

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1.22 The alga Lithophyllum lichenoides found in belts in the intertidal zone is included in annex I of the "Habitat" directive. This species is well represented along the battered granite and limestone coasts of the Strait of Bonifacio. The oldest and largest belts are found along the cliffs at Bonifacio and in the Lavezzi Islands.

1.23 Like other algae typical of sheltered sites in the infralittoral stage, certain types of Cystoseira have become rare because its habitat is suffering from pollution or eutrophication or has been destroyed by coastal management. Overgrazing by sea urchins, whose predators have been partially eliminated by man, also has to be taken into account. The Cystoseira are very well represented in the strait and certain species such as C. Funkii are

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predators have been partially eliminated by man, also has to be taken into account. The Cystoseira are very well represented in the strait and certain species such as C. Funkii are seen on rare occasions at near-surface depths (Ballesteros & Pineda, 2003).

Diversity

1.24 The number of species recorded to date in the Strait of Bonifacio is 1,745. Among the 977 species of fauna are 18 mammals, 165 birds, seven reptiles, two amphibians, 187 fish, 11 protochordates, 13 echinoderms, 262 insects, 11 arachnids, six bryozoans, 103 crustaceans, 143 molluscs, seven annelids, 23 cnidarians and 19 spongarians.

1.25 Considering the faunistic taxons as a whole, it should be noted that:

- Twenty-three animal species are of Community significance. Care of this area

is particularly important for two amphibians (Discoglossus sardus and Hyla arborea sarda), the bottlenose dolphin (Tursiops truncatus), chiroptera, marine molluscs, the fish Aphanius fasciatus , the loggerhead turtle Caretta caretta, the gecko Phyllodactylus europaeus , the lizards Podarcis tiliguerta and Lacerta bedriagae and the snake Coluber viridiflavus . Among the animal species of

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molluscs, the fish Aphanius fasciatus , the loggerhead turtle Caretta caretta, the gecko Phyllodactylus europaeus , the lizards Podarcis tiliguerta and Lacerta bedriagae and the snake Coluber viridiflavus . Among the animal species of Community significance whose capture in natural surroundings and cultivation can be managed, only the red coral Corallium rubrum , can be and is being cultivated;

- Seventy-seven taxons are listed in the "Birds" directive (all annexes combined). Among these birds are 16 species nesting in the area (including 10 from annex I), 24 regular migrants, 30 occasional migrants and five accidental migrants;

- The taxons strictly protected under t he Berne Convention (annex II) amount to 139, with 70 other species being considered as protected species whose exploitation must be regulated (annex III);